

2025/6/8 11:53 from Danilo's trip to where the Lahn meets the Rhine in Niederlahnstein

Rich Pickings

For centuries the territory along the River Lahn has been a border country. The river separates the archbishoprics of Mainz and Trier. Here on the Lahn the Elector of Trier collects tolls from all those travelling between the Rhine Valley

and the town of Nassau, seat of the counts of the same name. In the year 1348 he erected a land fortification on the banks of the Lahn to protect this lucrative source of revenue. It consists of a strong tower which permits surveillance of the river and the

road along the river bank. From now on the tower is manned by soldiers from the nearby fortress of Ehrenbreitstein. A small landing stage is constructed on the river bank in front of the tower and soon this also serves as a harbour.

In the year 1697, not far from the medieval toll tower, alderman Balthasar Kalkofen built a handsome house on the road beside the Lahn to provide refreshment and lodgings for the boatsmen and waggoners. The ground floor of solid quarystone walls is crowned by two upper storeys of elaborate half-timber work. The ensemble of buildings acquired its present form in 1741: the octagonal half-timbered tower with its concave roof and striking cupola is erected on the remains of the ruined toll fortification.

A two-storied trans-verse building now links the tower – known henceforth as the "round tower" and the house on the river bank.

The tavern becomes well-known through a popular folk song "The Lahn innkeeper's wife" which begins: "There is a tavern on the Lahn where all the waggoners rest". Written in the style of a limerick and continually added to, the song now has over 900 verses and probably goes back to Katharina, the wife of the first innkeeper.

From now on the buildings are collectively known as the "Tavern on the Lahn". This achieves lasting fame after the visit of a particularly illustrious guest: on July 18th 1774 Johann Wolfgang von Goethe dines here with his com-panions,

the clergyman Johann Caspar Lavater and the scholar Johann Bern-hard Basedow. Inspired by the sight of Lahneck Castle, Goethe writes his poem "Geistesgruss".

Today the ensemble still looks much the way it did when Goethe paid his visit. The house on the banks of the Lahn is still a place of excep-tional hospitality.

The Traveller's Rest

For hundreds of years this inn on the banks of the River Lahn has offered travellers food, drink and a bed for the night. The house was already famous in the days when people travelled by coach and horses, boat or on foot. Many songs

have been sung about it and it has been the subject of a film too.

A Unifying Factor

The Lahn has always separated the towns of Oberlahnstein and Nieder-lahnstein, and for many centuries during the Holy Roman Empire this small river also forms the border between the Electorates of Mainz and Trier. As the two powerful electors and archbishops are constantly fighting for supremacy on the Rhine, border disputes are common.

Only in modern times are the divisions gradually overcome. The 17th century saw a regular ferry service established for the first time between the two riverbanks. This makes it easier to cross the border. When the Duchy of Nassau was founded in 1806 a new state emerged which encompassed both banks of the Lahn. For the first time, the towns of Oberlahnstein and Niederlahnstein both belong to the same territory and people soon become interested in building a bridge to overcome the spatial separation.

In the mid 19th century a railway bridge was built across the Lahn. The first road bridge goes into service in 1873. The planning, financing and upkeep of the bridge repeatedly force both towns to cooperate. The bridge toll which is levied from 1873 to 1927 and from 1945 to 1949 is shared by both communities. The former bridge house with its kiosk still bears witness to this era.

The road bridge has to be rebuilt several times due to wear and tear, increased demand and the destruction of the Second World War. The fourth bridge construction which is still standing today was inaugurated in 1997. It is named after

Lahnstein's honorary citizen Rudi Geil who died in 2006. As a politician, he was always committed to achieving the union of Nieder- and Ober-lahnstein. They finally became one town in 1969.

The Baareschesser-Memorial near the Rudi-Geil-Bridge was designed by Fritz Berlin, a former mayor of the town of Oberlahnstein. It recalls the origins of the nickname of the residents of Niederlahnstein. This originated in the days

when there was no modern sewage system. In order to keep their groundwater clean, the people of Niederlahnstein did without cesspits and emptied their chamber pots-known in Lahnstein dialect as "Baar"-into the Lahn or emulated the bronze figure. For this reason they were called "Baareschesser" ("pot shitters") by the people of Ober-lahnstein.

Overcoming Boundaries

For many years Oberlahnstein and Niederlahnstein lay in two different states and the Lahn formed the border between the Electorates of Mainz and Trier. About 150 years ago the bridge over the Lahn was built creating a permanent link. Together

these two once independent communities now form the town of Lahnstein

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